

PowerPoint Basics — Detailed Lecture Notes

JKSSB Computer Awareness

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31.1 What PowerPoint is

MS PowerPoint is the presentation program of the MS Office suite. A **presentation** is a file made of one or more pages, and each page is called a **slide**. The slides are shown one after another as a **slide show** on a screen or projector. The official syllabus writes this unit as “Powerpoint Presentation”, and the usual short form is **PPT**. A single slide can hold text, pictures, charts, tables, audio, and video.

Definition (Presentation, slide, slide show). *A presentation is the whole file; a slide is one page of it; a slide show is the full-screen sequential display of those slides to an audience.*

Term	Meaning in this lesson
Presentation	The whole PowerPoint file, made of slides.
Slide	One page of the presentation.
Placeholder	The dotted-line box on a slide that holds content.
Layout	The arrangement of placeholders on a slide.
Theme	A coordinated set of colours, fonts, and effects.
Template	A ready-made starter file with a theme, layouts, and sample content.
Slide Master	The top-level slide that controls all linked layouts and slides.
Notes	The speaker’s reminders below a slide, unseen by the audience.
Handout	A printed sheet carrying several slides for the audience.

The rest of this lesson uses these terms in one consistent sense. A **slide** is the page, a **placeholder** is the box that holds content on that page, and a **layout** decides where those boxes sit. A **theme** restyles the file, a **template** starts a new file from a ready design, and the **Slide Master** controls the design of every linked slide at once.

31.2 Full forms and file extensions

Three full forms carry direct-recall marks. **PPT** stands for PowerPoint Presentation. **PPTX** stands for PowerPoint XML Presentation and is the default format since Office 2007. **PPSX** stands for PowerPoint Slide Show. Two more extensions complete the family: **POTX** is the PowerPoint Template, and **PPTM** is the macro-enabled presentation.

Definition (PowerPoint file extensions). *The editable working file uses .pptx; the template uses .potx; the show file that opens directly as a slide show uses .ppsx; the macro-enabled file uses .pptm. Presentations can also be saved or exported as .pdf.*

The working distinction is simple. Double-clicking a `.pptx` file opens it for editing, while double-clicking a `.ppsx` file launches the slide show directly. A `.potx` file is never the finished talk; it is the reusable pattern from which new talks are started. Confusing these three extensions is one of the most common wrong answers in this unit.

31.3 Slides, placeholders, and layouts

A slide is a single page of a presentation. Content is not typed freely onto the page background; it goes into **placeholders**, the dotted-line boxes marked Title, Text, Picture, Chart, or Table. Clicking inside a placeholder allows typing, and the small icons inside a content placeholder insert a picture, chart, table, or SmartArt graphic directly.

Definition (Placeholder). *A dotted-line container on a slide that holds one kind of content (title, text, picture, chart, table, or media).*

A **layout** is the arrangement of those placeholders. The common layouts are Title Slide, Title and Content, Section Header, Two Content, Comparison, Title Only, and Blank. A new slide is added from the Home tab through New Slide, which also offers the layout gallery; the layout of an existing slide is changed through Home tab to Layout. The Blank layout carries no placeholders at all, so every object on it must be inserted by hand.

Example 31.3.1. *A student builds a five-slide class talk on the office desktop. The first slide uses the Title Slide layout (one title plus one subtitle placeholder); each following point uses Title and Content; the closing slide reuses Section Header. Changing the layout of slide 3 from Title and Content to Two Content rearranges only slide 3; nothing else in the file moves.*

31.4 Themes, templates, and the Slide Master

A **theme** is a coordinated set of colours, fonts, and effects applied from the Design tab. One click restyles every slide in the file, because the theme is a design rule, not content. A **template** is a ready-made pattern file (extension `.potx`) that bundles a theme with a set of layouts and sometimes sample text. Starting a new presentation from a template reuses that whole design instead of building it again.

Definition (Theme and template). *A theme is a coordinated set of colours, fonts, and effects. A template is a reusable starter file (`.potx`) carrying a theme plus layouts and sample content.*

The **Slide Master** is the top-level slide that controls the design of all layouts and slides linked to it. Editing the font, the logo position, or the footer on the Slide Master changes every linked slide at once, which is far faster than editing forty slides one by one. It is opened from the View tab through Slide Master and left through Close Master View. PowerPoint has three masters in total: the Slide Master for on-screen slides, the **Handout Master** for printed handout layouts, and the **Notes Master** for printed notes pages.

Example 31.4.1. *An item states, “The Handout Master controls the design of all on-screen slides.” This is wrong. The Slide Master controls the on-screen slides; the Handout Master controls only the printed handout layouts. The wrong option has swapped two of the three masters.*

31.5 Views: Normal, Outline, Sorter, Reading, Show, Notes Page

PowerPoint offers several views, each with one job. **Normal view** is the default editing view, with three areas: the large slide pane in the centre, the slides or outline pane with thumbnails on the

left, and the notes pane below. All typing, formatting, and inserting happen here. **Outline View** shows only the text outline of every slide, which suits restructuring long talks.

Slide Sorter view shows thumbnails of all slides together, so slides can be reordered by drag and drop and checked, deleted, or duplicated at a glance. **Reading View** shows the show almost full-screen for reading on the author's own screen, with simple navigation but without editing tools. **Slide Show view** is the real full-screen presentation to an audience. **Notes Page view** shows one slide above its speaker-notes text, one page per slide, exactly as it will print.

Definition (Normal view). *The default editing view of PowerPoint, combining the slide pane, the slides or outline pane, and the notes pane.*

Example 31.5.1. *A student has twelve slides in the wrong order. The fastest fix is Slide Sorter view: drag the thumbnails into the right sequence. Opening each slide in Normal view and cutting and pasting would work but wastes time; choosing Reading View would not help at all, because Reading View cannot reorder anything.*

31.6 Notes, handouts, and printing

Notes (speaker notes) are reminders typed in the notes pane below a slide. The audience never sees them during the show; they exist so the speaker does not forget a figure, a definition, or the next point. During the show the speaker reads them only in Presenter View on the speaker's own screen. Notes print through File to Print to Notes Pages.

Definition (Speaker notes and handouts). *Speaker notes help the speaker and stay hidden from the audience. Handouts help the audience and are printed sheets carrying several slides per page.*

Handouts are those printed sheets: 1, 2, 3, 4, 6, or 9 slides per page. The most examined choice is 6 slides per page, and the 3-per-page layout adds ruled lines beside each slide so the audience can write. Their design is controlled by the Handout Master. The full print path is File to Print, with choices for Full Page Slides, Handouts, Notes Pages, and Outline View.

31.7 Running and navigating the slide show

Two shortcuts start the show. **F5** begins from the first slide, and **Shift+F5** begins from the current slide. This pair is a confirmed past item (WO 2026 Q80 tested F5 for “from the beginning”). During the show, N, Space, Right arrow, or Enter moves forward; P or Left arrow moves back; Esc ends the show. Pressing B blanks the screen to black and pressing W blanks it to white, which is useful while the speaker talks without a slide. The Slide Show tab holds timing, rehearsal, and monitor settings.

A **transition** is the movement between one slide and the next (Fade, Push, Wipe, Morph), set on the Transitions tab with one transition per slide. An **animation** is the movement of an object on a slide, set on the Animations tab: Entrance, Emphasis, Exit, and Motion Paths, managed in the Animation Pane. SmartArt conversion behaviour (which content cannot convert without re-entry) has also been examined (JA 2026 Q77), so candidates should practise the Insert to SmartArt path on text and picture lists rather than assume every object converts.

31.8 Exam retrieval and common confusions

Six distinctions prevent most errors on this topic.

1. The **slide** is the page; the **placeholder** is the dotted box holding content; the **layout** arranges those boxes.
2. **.pptx** is the editable file, **.ppsx** is the show file, and **.potx** is the template. Do not swap them.
3. A **theme** restyles (colours, fonts, effects); a **template** is the reusable starter file.
4. The **Slide Master** controls on-screen slides; the Handout and Notes Masters control print layouts.
5. **Normal** is the default editing view; **Slide Sorter** reorders; Reading reviews; **notes** serve the speaker and **handouts** serve the audience.
6. **F5** starts from the beginning and **Shift+F5** from the current slide; a **transition** moves between slides while an **animation** moves objects on a slide.

Example 31.8.1. *An item asks which view is the default editing view and offers Normal, Slide Sorter, Reading, and Slide Show. Trace the definitions: Normal is the editing view with the slide, thumbnail, and notes panes; Slide Sorter manages order; Reading reviews; Slide Show presents. The answer is Normal view. If the stem instead asks which view reorders slides by drag and drop, the answer changes to Slide Sorter.*

Exercises

1. Distinguish a slide, a placeholder, and a layout, giving one example of each.
2. Expand PPT, PPTX, and PPSX, and state the file extension of a PowerPoint template.
3. Distinguish a theme from a template.
4. What does the Slide Master control, and how do the Handout and Notes Masters differ from it?
5. List four PowerPoint views and state the job of each.
6. Distinguish speaker notes from handouts, and state which viewers each serves.
7. Which keys start a show from the beginning and from the current slide, and which key ends the show?
8. Distinguish a transition from an animation.

Solutions

1. A slide is one page of the presentation (for example, slide 2 of a class talk). A placeholder is the dotted-line box holding content on that page (for example, the Title placeholder). A layout is the arrangement of those boxes (for example, Title and Content).
2. PPT is PowerPoint Presentation; PPTX is PowerPoint XML Presentation; PPSX is PowerPoint Slide Show. A PowerPoint template uses **.potx**.
3. A theme is a coordinated set of colours, fonts, and effects that restyles a file; a template is a reusable starter file (**.potx**) that bundles a theme with layouts and sample content.

4. The Slide Master controls the design of all linked on-screen slides and layouts. The Handout Master controls printed handout layouts and the Notes Master controls printed notes pages; neither restyles the on-screen slides.
5. Normal is the default editing view; Slide Sorter shows thumbnails for reordering; Reading View shows the show for on-screen review; Slide Show presents full-screen; Notes Page shows one slide above its notes text. Any four with correct jobs earn full credit.
6. Speaker notes are the speaker's hidden reminders below a slide; they serve the speaker. Handouts are printed multi-slide sheets; they serve the audience.
7. F5 starts from the beginning; Shift+F5 starts from the current slide; Esc ends the show.
8. A transition is the movement between one slide and the next; an animation is the movement of an object on a slide (Entrance, Emphasis, Exit, Motion Paths).